

Two Mile Borris Tidy Towns Guiding Principles

These principles describe how the committee operates: how we choose what to plant where, how we spend money, who we work with, and how we keep records. Reviewed annually with the 3-5 year plan.

1. Planting policy: what goes where

The committee maintains three categories of planted space, each with a different purpose and a different default species choice.

Trough planters and raised beds (the cohesive village-wide blue planter scheme: cemetery layby, Meadow Brook entrance, the former Dempsey & Harold Motors site, the school's 1846 plaque on the L4202, plus the older concrete and plastic planters at Corcoran's and similar spots that we are filling with split perennials as the existing annuals die back). Limited soil volume and roadside exposure mean these need the hardiest, longest-flowering pollinator-friendly perennials we can find rather than a strictly native mix. Default: clump-forming pollinator perennials we can divide ourselves between beds.

In-ground beds (the main flower bed at the monument area, the named beds at the cemetery entrance and at estate entrances, the Sensory Garden beds). Sufficient soil and root depth to grow a wider mix. Default: pollinator-friendly perennials layered to give continuous flowering from March to October, with native and near-native species used wherever they cope with the conditions. Seed-heads are left for birds in autumn; cutting back is delayed to early spring.

Wildflower areas and unmown verges (St James Church grounds, Leighton Manor estate entrance with the existing allium-and-chamomile strip, Glen Carraig estate entrance once the estate agrees, Castlepark sycamore-corner border, and the proposed inside strips of approach-road verges once council Roads agrees). Default: no sown seed mix at all. We let the existing native seed bank emerge, manage by removing dock and thistle periodically from April to September, and cut-and-remove in autumn to keep soil nutrients low. Longer term, we would like to add "Managed for wildlife" signage, which explains the intent. This follows the All-Ireland Pollinator Plan grassland guidance.

Species choice criteria, in order of priority:

1. **Pollinator value first.** Every variety in the planter and bed mix earns its keep on the All-Ireland Pollinator Plan plant list.
2. **Subdividable.** Clump-forming so we can split our own existing stock between beds rather than buying in fresh annuals each year. This is how we keep ongoing cost down to almost nothing.
3. **Long flowering season.** We aim for continuous flowering from March to October across the village's planted areas, no hungry gaps for pollinators.
4. **Hardy.** Roadside conditions (full sun, free-draining soil, occasional salt spray) rule out a lot of fancier garden options. Anything that cannot cope does not earn a spot.
5. **Simple open flowers.** Single-flowered cultivars over double-flowered, so short-tongued bees can actually access the nectar. No heavily bred cultivars with little or no pollen.
6. **Native and near-native where they cope.** Where a native option meets the four criteria above, it wins. Where it does not, a near-native that does is preferred to a poor-condition native.

7. **Red and yellow as the core colours.** The village flag colours, picked up across the planter scheme and the monument-area bed.
 8. **Value for money.** Where two species meet the criteria, the cheaper one wins.
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2. Cost discipline

- Own-funds budget cap: ≤ €600 per year unless an external grant is secured.
 - Any single project costing more than €200 must have a funding source identified before the committee commits.
 - Grant-funded projects are tracked separately and do not consume own-funds budget.
 - Local nurseries and hardware shops are preferred where price is comparable.
 - "Defer don't drop": ambitious projects we can't afford stay on the register as grant-conditional rather than being abandoned.
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3. Partnerships first

We borrow expertise rather than try to build it ourselves. Our standing partners:

- **Tipperary County Council Heritage Officer, Róisín O Grady**
(roisin.ogrady@tipperarycoco.ie): heritage building advice and funding routes (forge replica window, heritage signage, Built Heritage Investment Scheme applications). Contacted directly for technical heritage questions; non-specialist county items still routed via Michael Maher's discussion list.
- **Tipperary County Council Biodiversity Officer, Ann-Marie Fleming**
(annmarie.fleming@tipperarycoco.ie): species selection and management advice for the graveyard scheme and any biodiversity-rich planting.
- **Parish Pastoral Council, St James Church:** named co-designer and co-deliverer on the *Returning to Nature* programme covering church grounds and cemetery.
- **Two Mile Borris National School:** Green Schools partner, with teacher Joann Cussen leading the school's Green Flag application; the school's biodiversity work is part of our village biodiversity story.
- **All-Ireland Pollinator Plan / Pollinators.ie:** species lists, grassland management guidance, monitoring methodology. The default reference for any planting question.
- **Faith Community Pollinator Plan:** operational management framework for the church-grounds 30% area under *Returning to Nature*.

Partners are named explicitly in the application narrative.

4. Documentation

- Photograph year-round across spring, summer, autumn and winter.
- Log clean-up dates and headcounts, FIT count results, planting decisions and species used, and any fly-tipping reports at the time.

- The committee maintains a public project tracker so residents and adjudicators can see what we are doing, what is planned, and at what stage.
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5. Adjudicator recommendations

- Address every recommendation every year, even if the action is only an email or a piece of signage.
 - No recommendation is ignored two years running. A recommendation that carries over twice is treated as urgent.
 - Action taken is recorded explicitly in the next application ("In response to the 2025 adjudicator's recommendation, we did X").
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6. Review

Reviewed annually at the post-results committee meeting (typically September after July adjudication), alongside the 3-5 year plan and the project register. Where a principle produces a result the committee thinks is wrong, the principle is updated rather than worked around.